

Phishing Awareness Training

A short reference for spotting and handling suspicious email



Phishing is still the easiest way for an attacker to get into a company — far easier than breaking through a firewall. This guide covers what to look for in a suspicious email, how to tell how serious it is, and what to actually do about it.

1. Warning Signs to Look For

Most phishing emails give themselves away in a few places. None of these alone proves an email is fake, but the more of them you see, the more suspicious you should be.

The sender

- The domain is almost right but not quite — `paypa1.com`, `micros0ft-support.com`, an extra hyphen, a wrong TLD.
- The display name says one company but the actual address is a Gmail/Yahoo/random domain.
- You weren't expecting anything from this person or company.

The pressure

- A deadline that's suspiciously short — "within 24 hours" or "immediately."
- Threats: account suspension, legal trouble, a missed payment.
- A request that skips your normal process (e.g. wiring money without the usual approval).

The links and attachments

- The link text says one thing but hovering over it shows a different URL.
- A shortened link (`bit.ly`, `tinyurl`) that hides where it actually goes.
- An attachment you weren't expecting, especially `.zip`, `.exe`, or a Word/Excel file asking you to "enable content."

The writing itself

- Generic greeting — "Dear valued customer" instead of your name.
- Slightly off grammar, spacing, or logos that look a bit stretched or low-resolution.
- A request for a password, one-time code, or payment details by email — legitimate services almost never ask this way.

Common Examples of Phishing Emails:

1.1 Example 1:

Earn While You Learn: Remote Paid Work-Study with CARE

From: Leandro Mayta Gadea <787735458@futuraschools.edu.pe>

Date: Tue, 9/9/2025 7:50 AM

Dear Students,

We are pleased to share a remote job opportunity made available through the Office of Placement and Career Services in partnership with CARE. This role offers students the chance to earn \$20-\$30 per hour while building hands-on experience in research and administrative support as a Personal Assistant.

The role is fully remote and requires only 2-3 hours per week, depending on the complexity of assigned tasks. It is open to students from all fields of study and backgrounds.

To apply, please email the following information to care.recruit@workmail.com:

Full Name, Gender, Major, Date of Birth, Current Address, School Email and Personal Email, Contact Number.

As opportunities are limited, we encourage early applications. We look forward to reviewing your submission and wish you continued success in your academic journey.

Best regards,

Office of Placement and Career Services

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Header Field	Observation	Risk
From	Leandro Mayta Gadea <787735458@futuraschools.edu.pe>	Sender appears to be an individual from a school domain, not an official university placement office.
Subject	"Earn While You Learn: Remote Paid Work-Study with CARE"	Uses attractive employment-related wording to gain attention.
Date	Tue, 9/9/2025 7:50 AM	Normal-looking timestamp.
Reply/Application Address	care.recruit@workmail.com	Different from sender domain. Major red flag.

Apart from this Virus Total flagged the address as suspicious, so indeed it is a phishing email.

Risk: High (Reason: Personal Information (PII) Harvesting)

1.2 Example 2:

U.S Department of Homeland Security
Washington DC

Attention

Re: Your Tax Refund Claim.

We have received a tax refund filing in your favor but it was not done with inaccurate information. Please let us know if this is you and also send us your name, contact address and telephone number for onward confirmation.

Yours,

Charles Summer
jbdgr54@gmail.com

Please reply.

Field	Observation	Risk
Claimed Organization	U.S. Department of Homeland Security	High
Sender Name	Charles Summer	Suspicious
Sender Email	jbdgr54@gmail.com	High Risk
Subject	Tax Refund Claim	Common phishing lure

Risk: Critical , Government Impersonation Phishing

1.3 Example 3:

From: Erdem CETINKAYA <erdem.cetinkaya@koyuncu.com.tr>
 Date: October 9, 2024 at 3:33:47 AM PDT
 Subject: Affected by the Disaster? Apply for FEMA Assistance Today

Dear Applicant,

We are pleased to inform you that you may be eligible for FEMA Disaster Relief Assistance following the recent disaster.

This assistance can help with housing, repairs, and other essential needs. Please follow the steps below to apply and claim your benefits as soon as possible.

Steps to Claim Your Financial Assistance:

- Sign in to the FEMA Assistance Portal using your school or work email and password.
- Navigate to the "My Disaster Assistance" section in the portal.
- Complete the application form with the necessary details.
- Select your preferred method for receiving funds.
- Submit your application for review and approval.

Delivery Options:

- Direct Deposit: Funds will be deposited directly into your bank account within 1-2 business days.
- Check: Receive your funds by mail within 3-5 business days.

Please choose the option that best suits your needs.

Thank you for your prompt attention. We are committed to ensuring you receive the help you need. If you aren't eligible, you can fill the form for a family member eligible.

Sincerely,

The FEMA Disaster Assistance Team

www.fema.gov

Field	Observation	Risk
From Name	Erdem CETINKAYA	Suspicious
From Email	erdem.cetinkaya@koyuncu.com.tr	High
Claimed Organization	FEMA	High
Subject	FEMA Disaster Assistance	Common phishing lure
Recipient	Generic ("Dear Applicant")	Suspicious

Header Findings

- Sender domain is unrelated to FEMA.
- Email claims to represent FEMA but originates from a Turkish commercial domain.
- Strong indication of impersonation.

Risk: Critical , Confirmed Phishing Attempt (Credential Harvesting)

1.4 Example 4:

PayPal

Hi <user>,

24/7 Support : +1 808 210 2330

You have sent a payment of 405.99 to an Exchange for buying Crypto.

Transaction # : PPINVT-7392539-3176445.

PAYMENT DETAILS

Transfer Amount : \$356

Tax Amount : \$49.99

Currency : U.S. Dollars

Quantity : 0.00152 BTC

Exchange Rate : \$42103.00

Final Amount : \$405.99

IPv6:2001:0cd8:83a3:0000:0000:7a2e:0570:722

The number above is Invoice # for this transaction. Please note it for your records so that you will be able to reference this transaction with Concern department.

For the verification reasons we have placed this invoice on hold for 24 hour. Please ignore this if you made this order. It will process itself or else kindly reach

our fraud protection department on +1 808 210 2330 to stop this Transaction within next 24 hour.

Or Go to Resolution center on your accounts home screen.

Sincerely,
PayPal

Field	Observation	Risk
Brand Used	PayPal	High-value impersonation target
Greeting	"Hi "	Generic
Sender Address	Not visible in screenshot	Unknown
Subject	Not visible	Unknown
Support Number	+1 808 210 2330	Suspicious

Risk: Confirmed PayPal Invoice Scam / Callback Phishing

1.5 Example 5:

From: <SUNet@stanford.edu>

Date: Tuesday, June 6, 2023 at 6:17 PM

To:

Subject: YMCA Job Offer

I am writing to share with you a job opportunity from YMCA. Currently, YMCA is seeking a temporary Personal Assistant to support in the procurement and distribution of essential products and services to those affected by the COVID-19 pandemic.

This is a part-time and home-based role, providing flexible hours and a salary of \$500/week. If you are interested in making a meaningful impact in people's lives and expanding your professional network, we encourage you to apply for this position.

To apply for this position, please refer to the 'YMCA Job Offer' word document attached and follow the instructions.

Thank you,

SUNet

Field	Observation	Risk
From	SUNet@stanford.edu	Medium
Subject	YMCA Job Offer	Medium
Date	June 6, 2023	Normal
Attachment Mentioned	Yes (Word Document)	High

Header Findings

- Appears to originate from a Stanford-related address.
- Uses a trusted institution to deliver a job offer.
- The actual sender infrastructure (SPF/DKIM/DMARC) cannot be verified from the screenshot.

Risk: High , Employment-Themed Phishing / Attachment-Based Recruitment Scam

2. Classifying the Risk

Safe — No significant phishing indicators; appears legitimate.

Suspicious — Some warning signs present; requires verification before trusting.

Phishing — Multiple strong indicators of fraud, impersonation, credential theft, malware, or social engineering.

3. How to Avoid Getting Caught Out

Before you click anything

- Hover over a link (don't click) and check where it actually leads.
- Look at the full sender address, not just the name that's displayed.
- If something feels off, slow down. Urgency is usually the point — that's exactly when to pause.

Around passwords and access

- Never enter your password or a one-time code on a page you got to by clicking a link in an email.
- Turn on multi-factor authentication everywhere it's offered — it won't stop every attack, but it stops most of them.

If you're not sure

- Contact the sender directly, through a phone number or channel you already know — not by replying to the email itself.
- Forward it to IT Security, or use the "Report Phishing" button if your mail client has one.
- If you've already clicked, entered a password, or opened an attachment — say so straight away. The faster it's reported, the easier it is to contain.

4. References

1. [VirusTotal](#)
2. [Recent Examples of Phishing | University IT](#)